

Background, early career and influences

Alexander's mother was Olympias, a princess from Epirus, and his father was Philip II, king of Macedonia. Plutarch says that Alexander was born on the same day in 356BC as the destruction by fire of one of the wonders of the ancient world, the temple of Artemis at Ephesus.

Olympias

Olympias' pregnancy was riddled by such signs and dreams. She reportedly dreamt of being struck on the womb by a bolt of lightning. A blinding flash followed, then a great sheet of fire that spread far and wide before it died away. Philip dreamt that he had sealed his new bride's womb using a seal bearing the figure of a lion.

Olympias was a proud, intelligent and ambitious woman. Plutarch describes her as 'a woman of jealous and vindictive temper, who incited Alexander to oppose his father' (Plutarch, *Life of Alexander*, 9).

Olympias was obsessed with her son and his eventual succession as the Macedonian king. The great number of stories regarding Alexander's supposed divine birth can probably be attributed to her influence. Whether

Alexander believed these stories is uncertain, but there is evidence that he greatly admired the heroes of Greece's past such as Achilles, from whom he was reportedly descended on his mother's side. It is said that he always kept a copy of the *Iliad* near him when he was on campaign. On his father's side Alexander was supposedly descended from Hercules and Perseus. These semi-divine personalities figure strongly throughout his career as influences on his actions.

Philip

Philip, king of Macedonia, had recently rebuilt the Macedonian state and promoted it to a leading position within the Balkan peninsula, both politically and militarily. Alexander



Review and analyse

- Using the information on pp137–8 create a timeline that shows the main events in Alexander's early life.
- List the names of the people mentioned that influenced Alexander's early life. Who were they? What was their relationship to Alexander? How did they influence his early life? Go to your library and, using a book like the *Oxford Classical Dictionary*, find out some more about them.
- What parts of Alexander's early life and education prepared him for (a) his life as a general, (b) his life as a king.
- In what way did Alexander go against the teachings of Aristotle? Why?
- Design an imaginary school report for the young Alexander. Make sure that you highlight his performance in the key subjects that he studied while growing up. You could model it on your school's report format.



Alexander the Great shown as Heracles wearing a lion's skin (above), from a silver coin, a tetradrachm, made at Amphipolis. Who was Heracles? Why might a person like Alexander want to show himself as Heracles on a coin?

A scene from the 'Alexander' mosaic from Pompeii showing what is thought to be Alexander in battle at Issus (left). What does this source tell us about the character of Alexander?